

Nudging

Final Project Guidelines

Timeline

- **Phase 1: Ideas & Background Research (10% of the grade)**
 - **Write a 1-2 page group memo** (submit memo by 9 AM on your Phase 1 presentation day)
 - * Describe your behavioral challenge and your ideas of the underlying behavioral drivers (a short behavioral audit).
 - * Identify at least 1 relevant empirical paper that will help you understand the challenge and/or develop and test an intervention, and describe the relevant findings.
 - * Describe your idea for an intervention and indicate which behavioral insights it is leveraging.
 - **Give a 5-min presentation** (submit slides by 9 AM on your Phase 1 presentation day)
 - * The presentation should briefly cover the content from the memo.
 - * But, you do not have to mention specific empirical papers.
- **Phase 2: Paper (40% of the grade)**
 - **Final paper** (submit paper by 9 AM on the day indicated in the syllabus)

Instructions below and in Final Project Slides (on Olat)

Submission: Upload presentation slides, phase 1 memo, and final paper to your group section on Olat in the Folder. See Final Project Slides for more details.

Steps to design & test your intervention

- **Identify an interesting question related to your assigned topic.**
 - Consider general questions that could be relevant to society/different organizations (e.g., *how can a coffee shop facilitate cup re-use? How can a charity solicit donations?*).
 - Consider particular organizations where you think you could test your intervention (e.g., *the University, local cafes, museums*).
 - The question should be related to **changeable human behavior**. *Do not choose a behavior that is mainly due to regulation, lack of resources or very ingrained personal or social values.*
 - The behavior should be **precise** and **measurable**.
 - *Refer to the Final Project Topic Ideas document for examples of specific challenges with measurable behavioral outcomes – you can pick one of these or come up with a new one.*
- **Research and analyze the topic in detail:**
 - **Do a behavioral Audit:**
 - * What are the drivers of behavior with respect to your specific challenge?

- * What are the behavioral barriers preventing people from engaging in the desired behavior?
- * *See details of how to do a behavioral audit in the Class 2 lecture slides.*
- **Research the setting/organization.** For example:
 - * *What do you know about the incentives/pricing scheme/promotions currently in place?*
 - * *Which kind of design is the website/app currently using?*
 - * *Which information is it providing to its users?*
 - * *Which kind of data can the organization collect (or is it already collecting)?*
- **Research interventions:**
 - * Is there existing work applying behavioral insights to this topic?
 - * What has already been tried by similar organizations?
- **Propose an intervention to address the behavioral challenge.**
 - Your proposed solution should be grounded in behavioral economics and based on your behavioral audit. Consider what you want to do with your intervention. For example, you can:
 - * *Leverage behavioral “mistakes” to change behavior (e.g., use defaults).*
 - * *Make long-term rewards or short-term costs most salient.*
 - * *Use behavioral insights to supercharge incentives or improve information.*
 - Be creative: develop a new intervention or propose new ways to combine multiple nudges.
- **Design and run an experiment to test the effectiveness of your intervention.**
 - *See the Class 9 lecture slides and consult the relevant class readings on how best to design an experiment.*
 - You can collect this data in the field or online.
 - If you choose to conduct an online study:
 - * you can use <https://www.soscsurvey.de> or a survey-building program of your choice.
 - * you can send the study to your social networks (friends and family).

Final Paper Guideline

Your final paper should be **10-12 pages**, not including references, appendices, figures.

It will be graded out of 30 points, and should address the following:

1. Motivation (3 points)

- Describe your specific challenge: what is the precise behavior you would like to change?
- Why is this question interesting? Why is it important?
- For which kind of organizations is this question relevant? (e.g., *non-profits/charitable causes, online websites, restaurants, universities, etc.*)
- Which kind of interventions have already been tried for solving this or related challenges?

- *Read the introductions of several academic papers to get an idea of how to write an introduction.*

2. Behavioral Audit (6 points)

- Use the behavioral economics literature **to review all (and only) the relevant factors** which contribute to this challenge. Review the literature from class and do your own research. Show a **good and accurate understanding of the concepts**.
- Consider why people do or don't engage in the relevant behavior.
 - Do people want to change this behavior?
 - Do they lack the resources, ability or information to change this behavior?
 - Consider **cognitive** (e.g. beliefs, attitudes, values, biases), **psychological** (e.g. emotions, affect), **physiological** (e.g. hunger, fatigue) and **behavioral** (e.g. habits) factors.
 - *See details of how to do a behavioral audit in the Class 2 lecture slides.*

3. Behavioral Intervention (7 points)

- Describe the *intervention* (not the experiment you will run to test it).
- This section should answer all of the following questions that are relevant:
 - Which behavioral insights is the intervention based on and which barriers does it address?
 - * **It may either directly address the factors underlying the behavior** (i.e. design text-message prompts to counteract forgetfulness) **or target behavioral factors that may not contribute to the behavior but can effectively change it.**
 - What is the evidence that it will be effective, that it won't backfire?
 - * Why might it work better than standard, non-behavioral interventions?
 - * Has this intervention (or a similar intervention focused on these insights) worked in other settings? If not, what inspired you to focus on this particular intervention?
 - * What variations might make it more or less effective? (e.g., framing).
 - Costs and benefits (direct & indirect; long & short term)
 - * Do the expected benefits justify the costs?
 - * How easy will it be to implement
 - How do you expect it to impact behavior?
 - * Will it solve or mitigate the problem behavior?
 - * Can it have any unintended consequences?
 - Why is your intervention novel/creative?

The first 3 sections are where you should include the majority of your literature review (citations of empirical academic papers). **You should aim to cite at least 10 relevant papers.**

4. Experiment (7 points)

- Experiment: Describe the experiment you ran to test the effectiveness of your intervention.

- Methods:
 - * What are the subjects, methods, materials?
 - * What are your experimental groups and how were participants randomized?
 - * What did you measure?
- Results:
 - * Both descriptive and statistical analyses.
 - * *See class 9 slides, read the results sections of academic papers.*
- Discussion:
 - * Discuss the implications of the results for the efficacy of your proposed intervention. Does your experiment suggest that the intervention would work?
 - * Discuss the limitations of your experiment, such as:
 - Small sample size
 - Imperfect randomization
 - Other unavoidable flaws/problems

5. Discussion (4 points)

- **Scaling up:** Propose a way to test your intervention on a larger scale (if you were testing this with more time and resources, what design would you use?)
- **Implementing:** If your intervention works, discuss how it would be implemented.
- **Discuss any possible issues with your intervention:**
 - Is it easy to implement?
 - Are there any ethical or legal concerns?
 - Can it be used long term, or would it be effective only in the short term?
- **Future directions:** What other interventions should be tested?

6. Format (3 points)

- Stay within the page limit.
- Revise and proofread your work and use clear and precise language.
- Organize your thoughts coherently and compellingly and employ good transitions between ideas and paragraphs. (*e.g., introduce your topic, intervention or experiment before giving details*).
- **Cite your sources.** You do not have to cite basic behavioral economics concepts like loss aversion, but, if you are referencing a specific study or finding, you must cite the relevant paper. You can use whatever citation format you are most comfortable with, such as [APA citation guidelines](#).
- **If your experiment included a survey, add an appendix at the end of the paper with the exact survey text and questions.**
- **On the title page of the final paper, you must specify each group member's roles in the Final Project. (See Final Project Slides for more information). In most situations, your group will receive one grade, which means that each member is responsible for the quality of the entire project. However, in the (hopefully) rare case of a stark disparity between the amount and/or quality of the contribution of a particular group member with the rest of the team, I reserve the right to assign that individual group member a lower grade.**